At the same time, Indians have had no qualms in anchoring external relations in ‘Realism’. From ancient times, realist and idealist philosophies have coexisted in India and the post-Independence era is no exception. Indians reflect a cultural ability to entertain seemingly contradictory thoughts parallel to each other. Belief in moral principles did not turn Indian leaders into pacifists. Notwithstanding messianic idealism, New Delhi has always recognized the importance of hard power. Indian foreign policy has woven into its thread the ideas of ancient Indian thinker Kautilya (also known as Chanakya), who is sometimes referred to as India’s Machiavelli. Kautilya argued that a state should be willing to use any of the following four means to achieve its goals: *Saam, Daan, Dand* and *Bhed* (persuade, gift, punish and divide).

For all its messianic idealism the Indian state has a Hobbesian view of the world where India can depend only on itself. This explains the strong desire for strategic autonomy, the push for economic autarky and the pursuit of military self-sufficiency. Indian leaders from Nehru onwards have recognized the importance of all elements of national power, including military power. The emphasis on economic growth in recent years is also tied to the realization that India’s great power ambitions would not be realized without having the means to pay for a strong military, among other things.

While desirous of playing a global role, India has also been reluctant to be drawn into global issues or ideologies. There is a strong streak of ‘Isolationism’ in India’s global outlook. It is one of India’s many paradoxes that it wants to be seen as a great power and is still often reluctant to do what is required of most great powers. Ironically, the British were the first power/empire in India that had an outward world view. Until the advent of the Raj, with the exception of the ancient south Indian Chola dynasty, no other Indian empire had sought to extend itself beyond the Indian subcontinent. Indian philosophers too asserted that would-be emperors or